SEVEN

Pakistan's Proxy War and Kashmir's *Azaadi* Revolution

With no Soviet troops left to fight in Afghanistan, Pakistan's ISI vigorously focused its attention on Kashmir, encouraging unemployed mujahideen to help them liberate it from the steel grip of India's strongly entrenched army in the Vale. Indira Gandhi's last decade in power had proved as tragic for Kashmir as it did for Punjab. Her victory over Pakistan in the Bangladesh War and the success of India's first plutonium explosion in 1974 had raised her to so powerful a position, not only in New Delhi but throughout the world, that Indira Gandhi seemed to have lost her judgment, and certainly her patience with any opposition. She behaved as though she considered herself omniscient, and listened more to the rash and foolish advice of her ambitious younger son, Sanjay, than to any of her father's old friends and wisest advisers, like Jaya Prakash Narayan and Morarji Desai. Thus, in 1975, when Allahabad's High Court found her guilty of campaign malpractice, a crime that should have barred her from elective office for six years, instead of handing over her powers to senior colleagues in her own Congress Party, at least until the Supreme Court could decide her appeal, Gandhi suspended India's Constitution, declaring a national "Emergency." All opposition parties and papers were banned, leaders were arrested, and every prison in India was filled with courageous freedom-fighters who had, like her own father, been treated much the same way by British imperial rulers.

Indira Gandhi's injudicious reaction to her conviction aroused India's best and bravest voices against her harsh dictatorship and tyranny, awakening Kashmir's young men and women, much as it did their